

Child Abuse — 50 Clinical Scenario MCQs with Answers & Rationales

1.

A 5-year-old boy is brought to the emergency department with multiple bruises on his back in various stages of healing. The mother says he “fell down the stairs.” What should the nurse do first?

- A. Ask the child privately what happened
- B. Document the mother’s statement only
- C. Discharge the child with home safety advice
- D. Delay action until a pattern is confirmed

 **Answer:** A

Rationale: The nurse should **assess privately** to get the child’s version without parental influence. Early, safe, and non-judgmental assessment helps identify possible abuse.

2.

A 7-year-old presents with a spiral fracture of the humerus. The caregiver says the child “fell off the couch.” What should the nurse suspect?

- A. Accidental injury
- B. Child neglect
- C. Physical abuse
- D. Bone fragility

 **Answer:** C

Rationale: **Spiral fractures** are often caused by twisting forces, highly suggestive of **non-accidental trauma (abuse)** in children.

3.

A nurse notices a child avoids eye contact and flinches whenever an adult raises their hand. What does this behavior indicate?

- A. Autism
- B. Possible physical abuse

- C. ADHD
- D. Shyness

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: **Flinching or avoidance** when adults move suddenly often signals **past physical abuse** and fear of being hit.

4.

A 3-year-old girl has genital bruising and complains of pain when urinating. What is the most appropriate nursing action?

- A. Ask the mother if the child fell
- B. Bathe the child to prevent infection
- C. Report the findings immediately
- D. Wait for lab results before acting

✓ **Answer:** C

Rationale: **Genital bruising** in a young child is **highly suspicious of sexual abuse** and must be **reported immediately** per legal duty.

5.

A 9-year-old boy is withdrawn, has poor hygiene, and is often hungry at school. What form of abuse is most likely?

- A. Physical abuse
- B. Neglect
- C. Emotional abuse
- D. Sexual abuse

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: **Neglect** involves failure to meet a child's basic needs such as food, hygiene, and care.

6.

A 6-year-old tells the nurse, "My dad burns me when he's angry." What should the nurse do first?

- A. Document and report to child protection services

- B. Ask the father for an explanation
- C. Promise secrecy to the child
- D. Tell the teacher to watch the child

✓ **Answer:** A

Rationale: The nurse must **report immediately** to authorities; it is **mandatory** and protects the child.

7.

Which injury pattern most suggests intentional harm?

- A. Bruises over shins
- B. Linear marks on back
- C. Scrapes on elbows
- D. Bruised knees

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: **Linear marks** (e.g., from a belt or stick) on areas not prone to accidental injury are classic signs of **physical abuse**.

8.

A 10-year-old with repeated STIs is found to have an adult boyfriend. Which type of abuse is this?

- A. Emotional abuse
- B. Sexual abuse
- C. Neglect
- D. Exploitation

✓ **Answer:** D

Rationale: **Using a child sexually for profit or advantage** is **child sexual exploitation** — a form of abuse and trafficking.

9.

A nurse suspects child abuse but is unsure. What is the most appropriate action?

- A. Wait until sure
- B. Report suspicion to authorities

- C. Ask the parent for confirmation
- D. Ignore to avoid conflict

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: Reporting suspicion is legally required. Proof is not needed; investigation is handled by professionals.

10.

A 2-year-old has multiple cigarette burns on the thighs. The caregiver says the child “plays with matches.” What’s the correct nursing response?

- A. Accept explanation
- B. Document and report
- C. Counsel the parent
- D. Apply ointment and discharge

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: Cigarette burns are **distinct, circular, and intentional injuries** — immediate reporting is essential.

11.

A child in foster care exhibits sexualized play behavior with dolls. This most likely indicates:

- A. Exposure to sexual abuse
- B. Normal curiosity
- C. Lack of parental guidance
- D. Poor socialization

✓ **Answer:** A

Rationale: Sexualized behavior beyond developmental norms strongly suggests **prior sexual abuse**.

12.

Which factor increases risk for child abuse?

- A. Supportive community
- B. Parental substance abuse

- C. Stable income
- D. Educated parents

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: **Parental substance use** (alcohol, drugs) is a major **risk factor** for neglect and violence.

13.

A 4-year-old has bruises in various healing stages. What does this suggest?

- A. A recent single injury
- B. Repeated trauma over time
- C. Poor nutrition
- D. Blood disorder

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: Injuries at **different healing stages** indicate **repeated abuse**, not a single incident.

14.

A nurse notes a child is overly affectionate toward strangers and lacks attachment to caregivers. Which type of abuse is suspected?

- A. Emotional neglect
- B. Sexual abuse
- C. Physical neglect
- D. Emotional abuse

✓ **Answer:** A

Rationale: **Lack of secure attachment** and **indiscriminate friendliness** suggest **emotional neglect**.

15.

A 12-year-old girl reports being touched inappropriately by a teacher. The nurse's next action should be:

- A. Reassure and report to authorities
- B. Ask her to confront the teacher

- C. Tell her to avoid the teacher
- D. Inform the teacher's colleague

✓ **Answer:** A

Rationale: **Mandatory reporting** is required. The nurse should comfort and **report immediately** to the child protection agency.

16.

A nurse observes a mother calling her child "stupid" and "useless" during a clinic visit. What type of abuse is this?

- A. Physical abuse
- B. Emotional abuse
- C. Neglect
- D. Verbal correction

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: **Constant humiliation or insults** cause **psychological harm**, fitting emotional abuse.

17.

A malnourished child with untreated asthma comes repeatedly to the clinic. What type of abuse?

- A. Physical
- B. Sexual
- C. Medical neglect
- D. Emotional

✓ **Answer:** C

Rationale: Failure to provide needed **medical care** constitutes **medical neglect**.

18.

A 13-year-old boy reports his stepfather beats him but begs the nurse not to tell anyone. The nurse should:

- A. Respect his wishes
- B. Report to child protection services

- C. Wait until next visit
- D. Confront the stepfather

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: Confidentiality is **secondary to safety** — the nurse must **report suspected abuse**.

19.

A 3-year-old comes to the clinic dirty, tired, and always alone. What is the nurse's best action?

- A. Scold the parent
- B. Report neglect
- C. Bathe the child
- D. Give food and discharge

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: Consistent signs of **neglect** must be **reported** to social services for protection.

20.

A child's injury doesn't match the caregiver's explanation. What should the nurse document?

- A. Only what the caregiver said
- B. Objective findings and statements
- C. The nurse's opinion
- D. None of the above

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: Documentation should be **factual and objective**, including **observations and exact quotes**.

21.

A 10-year-old is forced to work in a shop after school every day. Which term applies?

- A. Child neglect
- B. Child labor exploitation

- C. Physical abuse
- D. Emotional abuse

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: **Child labor** that interferes with education or well-being is **exploitation**.

22.

A child with bruises in the shape of a handprint is admitted. Which action is priority?

- A. Take photo documentation and report
- B. Give analgesics
- C. Counsel parents
- D. Discharge after care

✓ **Answer:** A

Rationale: **Hand-shaped bruises** clearly suggest **inflicted injury** — document and report immediately.

23.

A parent refuses to allow treatment for their severely injured child. The nurse should:

- A. Respect the parent's choice
- B. Seek court or child protection intervention
- C. Send the child home
- D. Wait for social worker

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: When a parent's decision endangers a child, **legal authorities** must intervene to protect the child's rights.

24.

Which situation indicates emotional neglect?

- A. No meals at home
- B. No affection or support
- C. Bruises on arms
- D. No schooling

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: Lack of **love, comfort, and attention** defines **emotional neglect**.

25.

A child discloses abuse to the nurse. What is the best response?

- A. "You're lying."
- B. "I believe you, and I'll help keep you safe."
- C. "Don't talk about it."
- D. "Why didn't you tell sooner?"

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: The nurse must **validate and support** the child, showing trust and ensuring protection.

26.

A 6-year-old with multiple bruises says, "Mom hits me because I'm bad." What is the nurse's best initial response?

- A. "You must have done something wrong."
- B. "It's not your fault that you're hurt."
- C. "You should behave better next time."
- D. "Don't tell anyone about this."

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: The child must be **reassured that the abuse is not their fault** to reduce guilt and build trust for disclosure.

27.

A nurse suspects that a 9-year-old with bruises is being abused. The parent insists the child is "clumsy." What should the nurse do next?

- A. Record findings objectively and report
- B. Accept the parent's statement
- C. Ignore unless new injuries occur
- D. Treat and discharge

✓ **Answer:** A

Rationale: **Objective documentation** and **immediate reporting** are mandatory when abuse is suspected — not waiting for proof.

28.

A 3-year-old presents with burns that are sharply demarcated around the ankles and wrists. Which type of abuse is likely?

- A. Neglect
- B. Physical abuse (restraint burns)
- C. Emotional abuse
- D. Sexual abuse

✓ **Answer: B**

Rationale: Patterned burns at restraint points indicate **intentional harm**, not accidental injury.

29.

A mother constantly threatens to abandon her child if he doesn't obey. What form of abuse is this?

- A. Emotional abuse
- B. Neglect
- C. Physical abuse
- D. Exploitation

✓ **Answer: A**

Rationale: Threatening abandonment is a form of **emotional abuse** causing psychological distress.

30.

A 5-year-old is underweight, has dental decay, and poor hygiene. His parents often leave him with neighbors. What type of maltreatment is this?

- A. Neglect
- B. Physical abuse
- C. Sexual abuse
- D. Exploitation

✓ **Answer: A**

Rationale: Failure to meet physical and hygienic needs defines **neglect**.

31.

During assessment, a nurse finds bruises on a child's inner thighs and buttocks. The child avoids sitting. What should the nurse suspect?

- A. Sexual abuse
- B. Neglect
- C. Accidental injury
- D. Nutritional deficiency

✓ **Answer:** A

Rationale: Bruises in **genital or inner thigh areas** are **strong indicators of sexual abuse**.

32.

A nurse observes that a caregiver shows no concern for a severely injured child. What might this behavior suggest?

- A. Appropriate detachment
- B. Possible child abuse or neglect
- C. Emotional exhaustion
- D. Normal coping

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: **Lack of concern** or indifference is a **warning sign** of abuse or neglect.

33.

A 2-year-old child is admitted with a fractured femur. The parent gives vague and changing explanations. What is the best nursing action?

- A. Report to child protective services
- B. Discharge after treatment
- C. Call the parent's friend for clarification
- D. Delay reporting

✓ **Answer:** A

Rationale: **Inconsistent injury explanations** strongly suggest **non-accidental trauma** — must be reported.

34.

Which behavior from a parent during assessment would raise suspicion of abuse?

- A. Concern for the child's comfort
- B. Blaming the child for injuries
- C. Asking questions about care
- D. Calm cooperation

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: **Blaming the child** for injuries reflects **defensiveness and potential guilt**, often linked to abuse.

35.

A nurse notices a 7-year-old's weight has not changed for a year despite no medical reason. Which type of maltreatment is most likely?

- A. Emotional neglect
- B. Nutritional neglect
- C. Physical abuse
- D. Exploitation

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: Failure to provide **adequate nutrition** leading to growth failure indicates **nutritional neglect**.

36.

A 14-year-old girl presents with depression and nightmares after being assaulted. What is the priority nursing intervention?

- A. Provide privacy and emotional support
- B. Tell her to move on
- C. Encourage silence
- D. Delay care until the police arrive

✓ **Answer:** A

Rationale: Victims of **sexual abuse** need **immediate psychological and emotional support** to reduce trauma.

37.

A 6-year-old is frequently left unsupervised at home while the parents work late. The child is often frightened. What type of abuse is this?

- A. Neglect
- B. Emotional abuse
- C. Exploitation
- D. Physical abuse

 **Answer:** A

Rationale: Leaving a young child alone without supervision constitutes neglect.

38.

A child has patterned bruises matching a belt buckle. The parent says the child "fell." What should the nurse conclude?

- A. Accidental injury
- B. Possible physical abuse
- C. Self-inflicted wound
- D. Play-related bruise

 **Answer:** B

Rationale: Patterned injuries (belt marks) are hallmark signs of inflicted trauma.

39.

A child refuses to go home after school and fears being alone with a parent. What should the nurse suspect?

- A. Normal behavior
- B. Possible abuse at home
- C. School phobia
- D. Anxiety disorder

 **Answer:** B

Rationale: Fear of going home or a caregiver suggests abuse in the home environment.

40.

A 3-year-old in the emergency room avoids looking at his mother and clings to the nurse. What might this indicate?

- A. Secure attachment
- B. Fear of the caregiver (possible abuse)
- C. Normal behavior
- D. Temper tantrum

 **Answer: B**

Rationale: Avoidance and fear toward the caregiver may indicate **abuse by that person**.

41.

A nurse documents that a child has multiple healed fractures. What type of abuse does this suggest?

- A. Emotional abuse
- B. Recurrent physical abuse
- C. Neglect
- D. Self-harm

 **Answer: B**

Rationale: Multiple fractures in various stages of healing are classic signs of **repeated physical abuse**.

42.

A 15-year-old girl is forced by relatives into marriage. This constitutes:

- A. Cultural norm
- B. Child exploitation and abuse
- C. Family tradition
- D. Not abuse

 **Answer: B**

Rationale: Forced child marriage is a form of **sexual exploitation and human rights abuse**.

43.

A nurse finds that a child with developmental delays is being locked in a room for hours. This is an example of:

- A. Physical restraint for safety
- B. Emotional and physical abuse
- C. Neglect only
- D. Discipline

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: **Confinement and isolation** are both **emotional and physical abuse**.

44.

A caregiver uses severe corporal punishment "to teach discipline." How should the nurse respond?

- A. Educate about positive parenting
- B. Praise firm discipline
- C. Ignore cultural differences
- D. Blame the parent

✓ **Answer:** A

Rationale: Nurses should **educate caregivers** on **non-violent discipline methods** to prevent future abuse.

45.

A nurse notes that a child frequently misses school without reason. Which form of maltreatment is likely?

- A. Educational neglect
- B. Emotional abuse
- C. Physical neglect
- D. Exploitation

✓ **Answer:** A

Rationale: **Failure to ensure school attendance** is **educational neglect**.

46.

A parent consistently fails to provide prescribed medication for a child with epilepsy. What is this?

- A. Emotional neglect
- B. Medical neglect
- C. Physical abuse
- D. Disciplinary issue

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: Failure to provide **essential medical treatment** constitutes **medical neglect**.

47.

A nurse is caring for a sexually abused child. Which nursing approach is most therapeutic?

- A. Maintain a calm, nonjudgmental demeanor
- B. Ask leading questions
- C. Show shock or anger
- D. Promise confidentiality

✓ **Answer:** A

Rationale: The nurse should provide a **safe, calm, and supportive environment** to encourage trust and disclosure.

48.

A nurse notices an infant with flat affect, minimal crying, and lack of eye contact. What might this indicate?

- A. Normal baby behavior
- B. Emotional deprivation
- C. Good adaptation
- D. Autism spectrum disorder only

✓ **Answer:** B

Rationale: **Lack of emotional responsiveness** in infants often results from **emotional neglect or deprivation**.

49.

A social worker brings a child from an abusive home to the ward. What is the nurse's **priority**?

- A. Build trust and ensure safety
- B. Ask about abuser details
- C. Return child home
- D. Delay care until police arrive

✓ **Answer:** A

Rationale: The **child's physical and emotional safety** is always the **first priority**.

50.

A nurse caring for an abused child must complete documentation. Which statement is correct?

- A. Include exact words from the child
- B. Use judgmental language
- C. Write personal opinions
- D. Avoid details

✓ **Answer:** A

Rationale: Documentation should be **objective, factual, and include direct quotes** to ensure legal accuracy.